

Open-air pantry

Using its hook-tipped beak, a male red-backed shrike impales a beetle on a thorn. The bird has already caught and spiked a lizard and a butterfly, and it will make more pantries when this one is full. When prey is easy to find, the shrike stores away its excess supplies in heathland trees or bushes and then returns to feed if food becomes scarce. Food storage is unusual among hunters, because dead prey is difficult to keep fresh. The shrike's storage system dries out the insects and small animals quickly, making them safe to eat over a period of time.

